

Base Metals Tracker: Copper: Physical Tightness vs. Fading Macro

- Copper's price action last week has captured the tension between tightening physical fundamentals and a less supportive macro backdrop. The LME copper price rose to a weekly high of around \$13,640/t as signs of physical tightening strengthened, with Chinese inventories drawing sharply and LME cancelled warrants rising. It then briefly fell towards \$13,400/t on Friday as broader risk-off sentiment intensified amid renewed Middle East tensions, more hawkish Fed repricing and Friday's sell-off in AI-linked chip stocks, before recovering to close at \$13,526/t on Friday.
- Our price decomposition shows that the AI complex has become an increasingly important driver of copper prices ([Exhibit 1](#)), less because current datacenter copper demand is large in absolute terms (~1% of total copper demand), and more because AI has become a key narrative shaping expectations for future power, grid and copper demand ([Exhibit 2](#)).
- Against a weaker macro backdrop, China's physical market has continued to tighten. China visible copper cathode inventories fell to 167kt, leaving stocks at the bottom of their seasonal range ([Exhibit 3](#)). Typhoon Bavi-related stockpiling and delays to cathode arrivals amplified the latest draw, but the disruption hit a market that already had little inventory cushion.
- We attribute the recent tightening mostly to substitution from scrap into cathode rather than to end demand. [Tighter VAT enforcement](#) on scrap in China has constrained domestic scrap circulation and kept secondary rod output unusually weak, shifting fabricators towards cathode-based rod ([Exhibit 4](#)). Concentrated smelter maintenance had also weighed on domestic cathode availability, with output falling month on month in June and remaining broadly flat YoY ([Exhibit 5](#)).
- We expect the ex-US copper market to remain tight near term, with the continued US import pull on tariff expectations drawing units away from an already thin ex-US market, and low Chinese inventories and limited scrap substitution cushioning the downside. We see near-term downside risk to copper prices if the Middle East conflict escalates further and adds to inflation and rate hike concerns, though renewed Fed hikes are not our [economists' base case](#).

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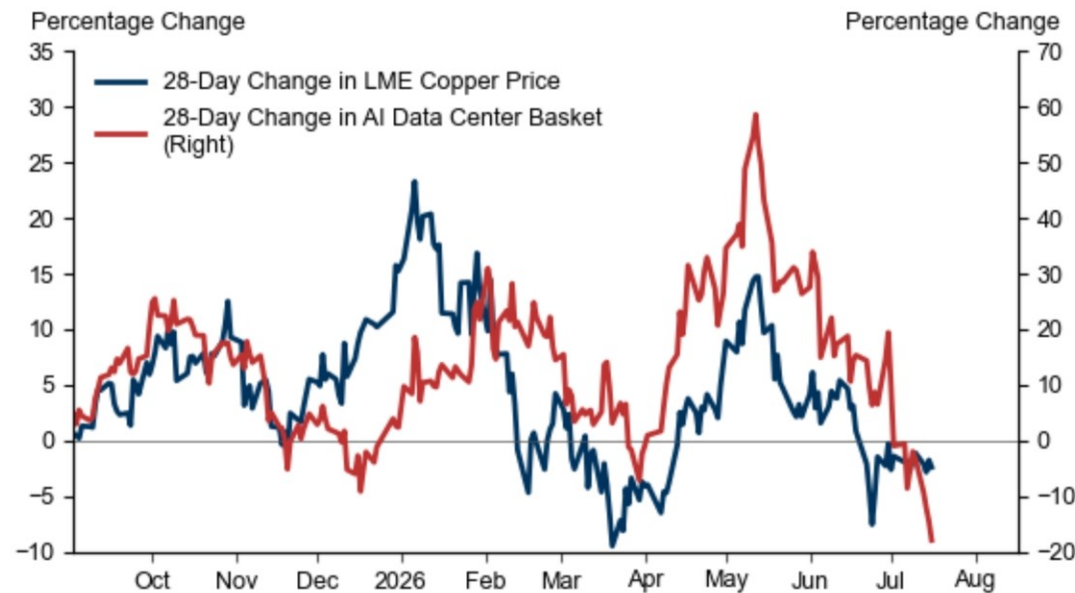
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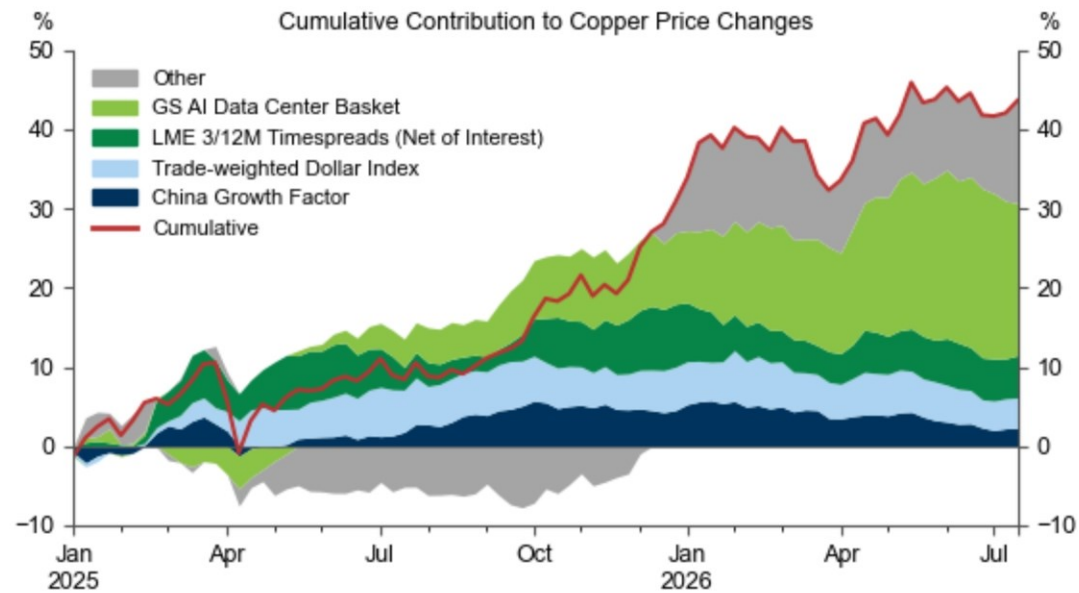
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Exhibit 1: The Correlation Between Copper and AI Datacenter Equities Has Risen Sharply Since Late 2025



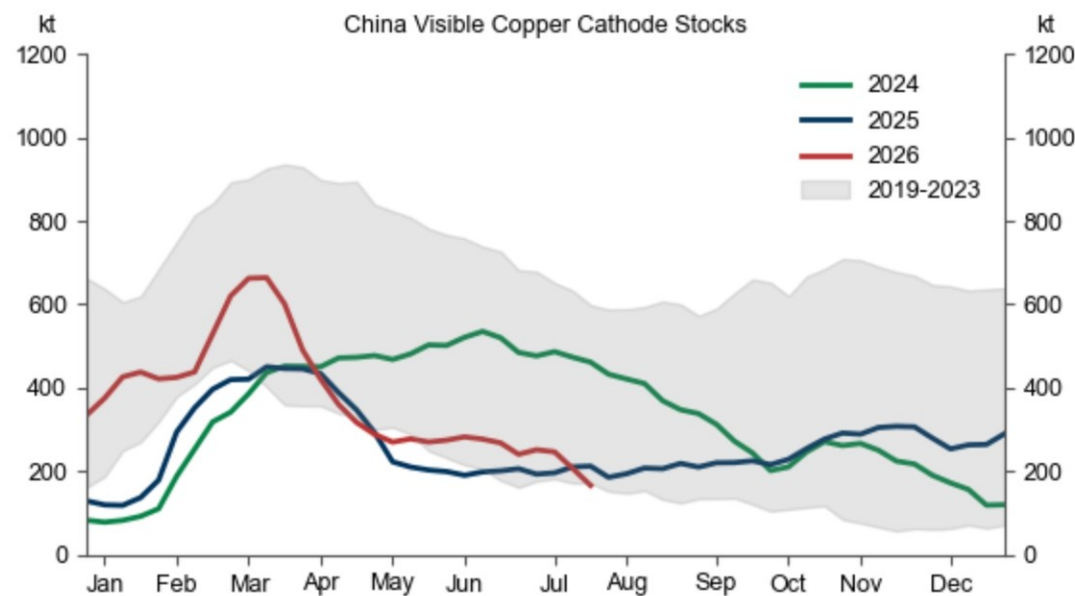
Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 2: AI Expectations Have Become an Increasingly Important Driver of Copper Prices

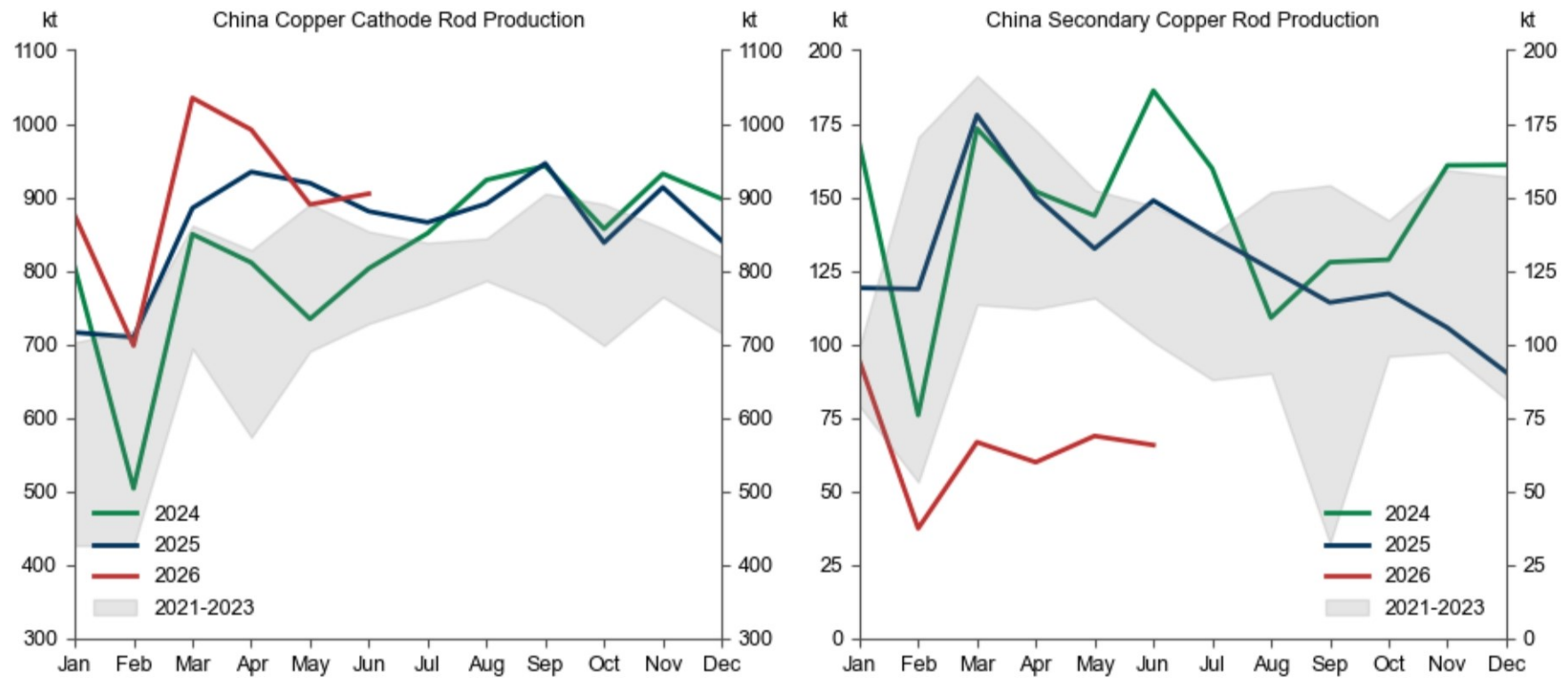
Model decomposition of weekly copper price changes regressed on changes in the GS Alternate China Growth Factor, the LME 3-month/12-month timespread (net of interest rate effect), the trade-weighted Dollar Index (DXY) and GS AI Data Center Basket. The GS Alternate China Growth Factor (Ex-Copper) is constructed as the first principal component of A- and H- shares, and first principal component of short- and long-term Chinese rates. "Other" captures the regression residual and constant term. The regression is estimated over 2024–2026 weekly data up to the week ending July 17th. Contributions are shown cumulatively from January 2025 onward.

Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

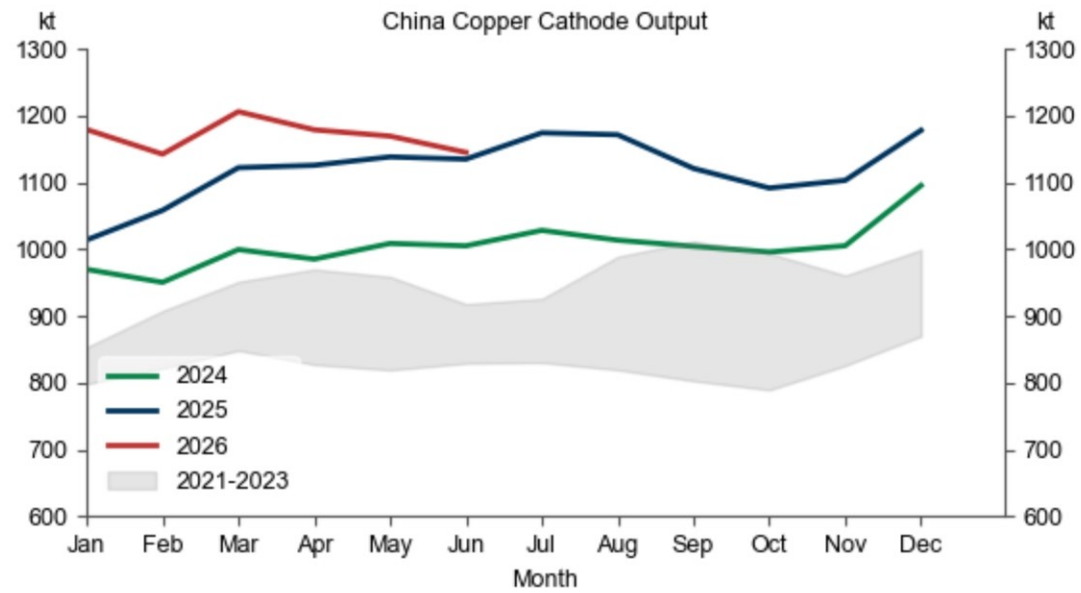
Exhibit 3: China Copper Inventories Have Fallen to Seasonal Lows



Source: Wind, SMM, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 4: Scrap Tightness Has Shifted Fabricator Demand Toward Refined Cathode

Source: SMM, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 5: China Cathode Output Fell Again in June

Source: SMM, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Price Table

Exhibit 6: Base Metals Prices Have Fallen Across the Complex Over the Past Month

	Unit	17 Jul 26	1 Week % Change	1 Month % Change	3 Months % Change	1 Year % Change	Spread (Cash - 3M) (%)	Spec Length Percentile (5 Years)	Price Percentile (5 Years)
COMEX Copper	\$/t	13812	-0	-3	1	12	-1	96	100
LME Copper	\$/t	13526	0	-1	1	38	-0	43	98
SHFE Copper	rmb/t	103810	-0	-1	2	33	0	61	97
LME Aluminium	\$/t	3150	0	-7	-12	20	0	80	88
SHFE Aluminium	rmb/t	23210	1	-3	-9	13	-0	36	89
Aluminium Midwest Premium	¢/lb	107	-3	-7	-1	57	-0	58	93
LME Nickel	\$/t	16961	1	-5	-6	11	-1	61	35
SHFE Nickel	rmb/t	130420	2	-4	-9	8	-0	37	33
LME Zinc	\$/t	3526	-3	-3	2	25	1	84	87
SHFE Zinc	rmb/t	24565	-1	-1	2	10	-0	71	76
LME Tin	\$/t	53230	0	-1	5	59	-1	50	97
LME Lead	\$/t	1883	-1	-5	-4	-6	-2	2	2
SHFE Rebar	rmb/t	3121	2	1	1	1	0	23	20
LME Rebar	\$/t	580	1	-1	-3	7	-0	43	40
SHFE Hot Rolled Coil	rmb/t	3308	1	-1	-0	-1	-0		19
LME Hot Rolled Coil	euro/t	720	0	7	1	33	-2		64
COMEX Hot Rolled Coil	\$/st	1178	1	2	9	39	0	89	83
SGX Iron Ore	\$/t	100	1	0	-7	-0	-1		18
SHFE Stainless Steel	rmb/t	14800	4	-2	-1	16	1		55
COMEX Lithium Hydroxide	\$/t	19370	-1	-3	-10	131	-2	98	47
COMEX Lithium Carbonate	\$/t	19980	-1	-6	-9	121	-2		74
COMEX Cobalt	\$/lb	26	0	-0	-0	66	3	85	81

Speculative positioning net length percentile refers to volume (rather than value).

Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Price Forecasts

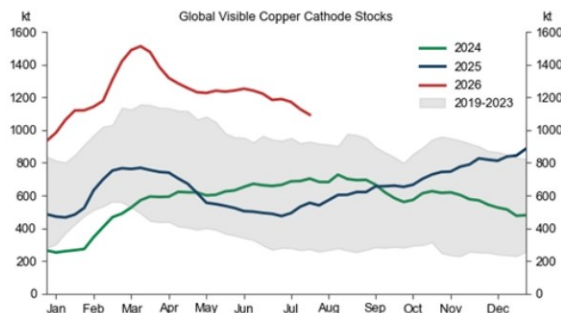
Exhibit 7: We Expect Aluminium Prices to Move Lower Over 2027

	Unit	17 July 2026	GS Forecast (Average)		
			2026	2027	2028
LME Copper	\$/t	13,526	13,400	13,800	13,700
LME Aluminium	\$/t	3,150	3,200	2,700	2,600
LME Nickel	\$/t	16,961	18,500	-	-

Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

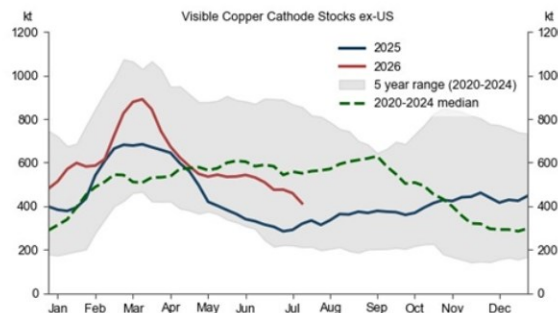
Copper: Physical Market Indicators

Exhibit 8: Global Visible Copper Inventories Have Declined, But Remain Above the Historical Seasonal Range



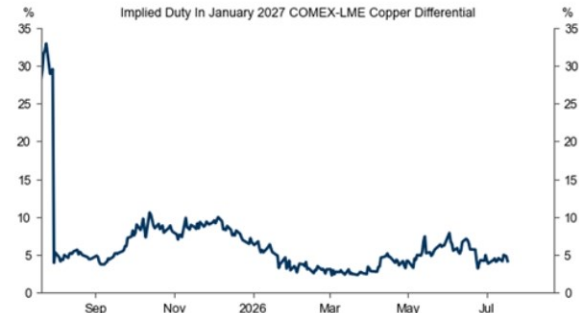
Source: Bloomberg, SMM, WIND, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 9: Ex-US Visible Copper Inventories Have Fallen as Metal Continues to Flow in the US



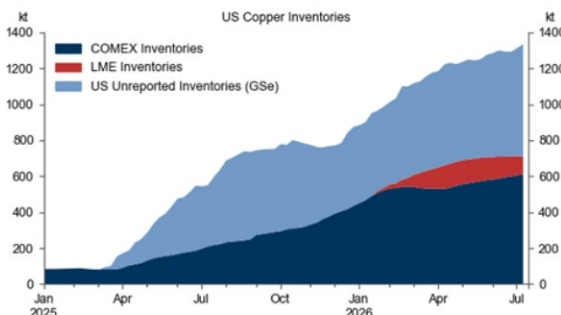
Source: Bloomberg, SMM, WIND, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 10: The Market is Pricing ~30% Probability of a 15% Refined Copper Tariff Being Implemented by January 2027



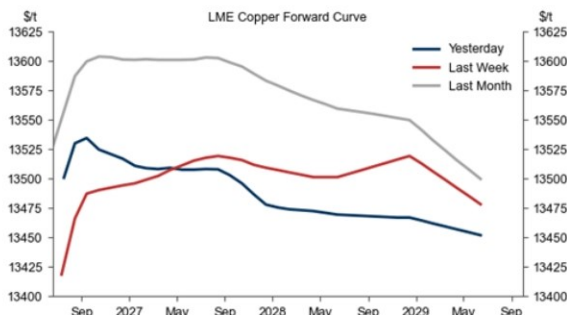
Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 11: US Copper Inventories Have Continued to Build on Tariff Expectations



Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

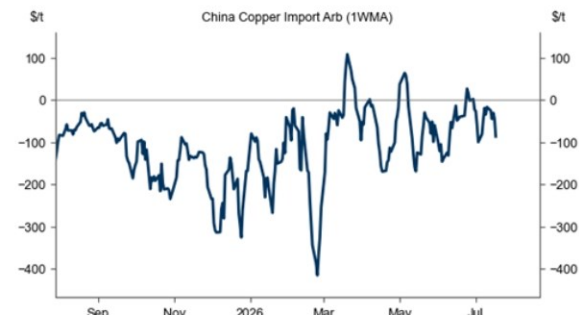
Exhibit 12: LME Copper Prices Have Moved Lower Across the Curve Over the Past Month



First point is LME cash.

Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 13: The China Copper Import Arbitrage Has Closed After Briefly Reopening

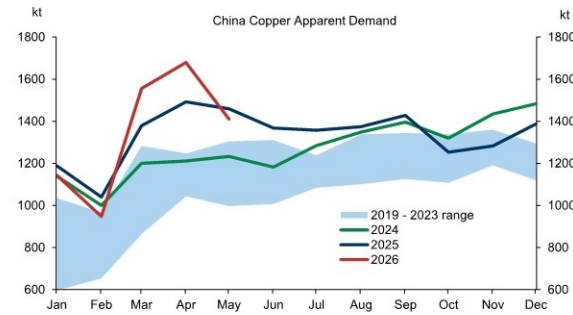


Above zero = incentive for China to import copper cathode. Copper arb is calculated by the SHFE price over LME (accounting for 13% VAT and other import costs).

Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

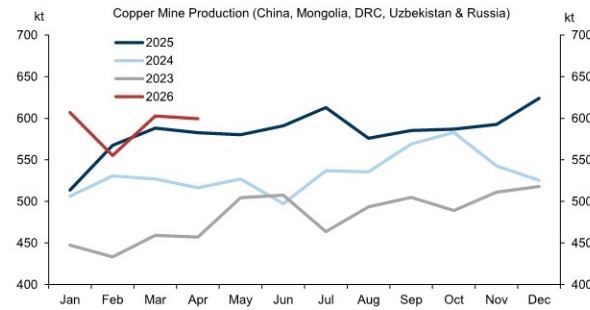
Copper: Supply & Demand Tracker

Exhibit 14: China Copper Apparent Demand is Up 2.7% YTD (Jan-May)



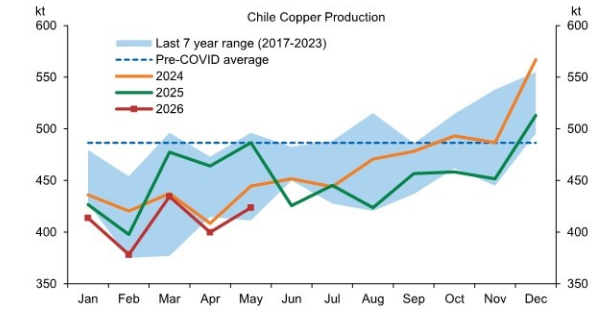
Source: Wind, SMM, GTT, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 15: Output from the Main Mine Supply Growth Countries Remains Above 2025 Levels



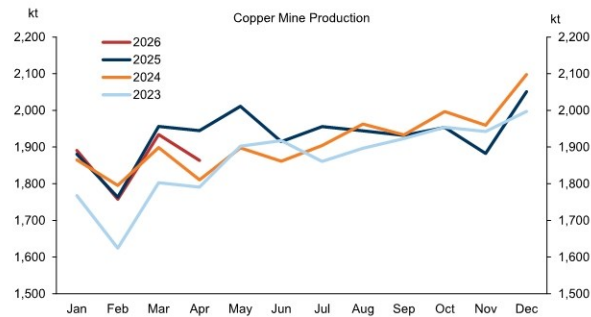
Source: Company filings, ICSG, Banque Centrale du Congo, GTT, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 16: Chile Copper Production is Down 9% YoY YTD



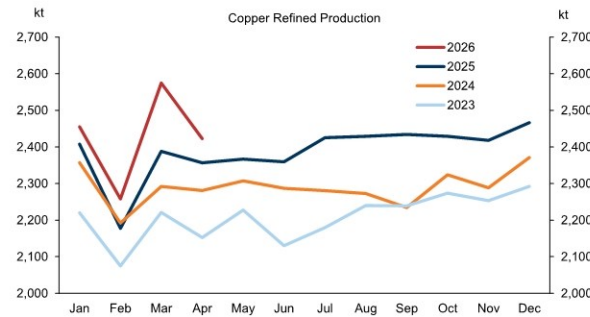
Source: Government Data, Haver Analytics, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 17: Global Copper Mine Production Has Weakened Since March



Source: ICSG, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 18: Refined Copper Production Has Remained Strong Despite Weaker Mine Supply



Source: iCSG, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

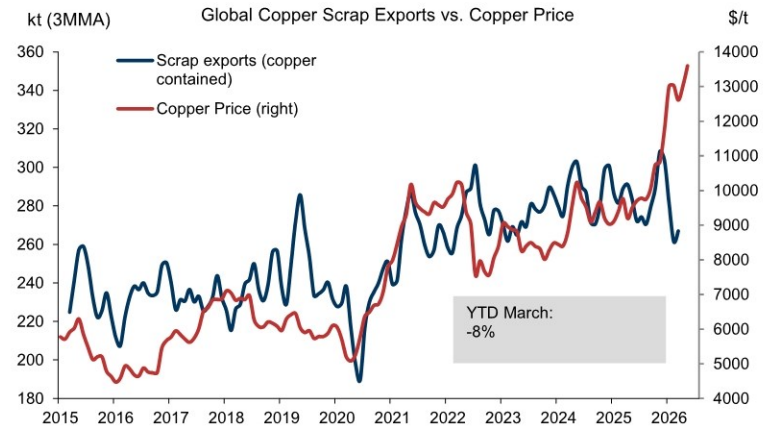
Copper: Forecast Tracker

Exhibit 19: Our Copper Price Forecast Is Modestly Above Forwards



Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

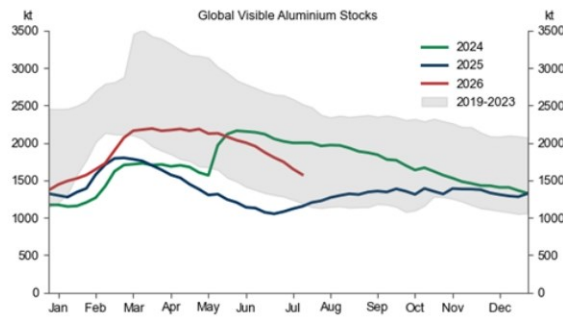
Exhibit 20: Global Copper Scrap Exports Have Fallen 8% YTD Despite Elevated Copper Prices



Source: GTT, Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

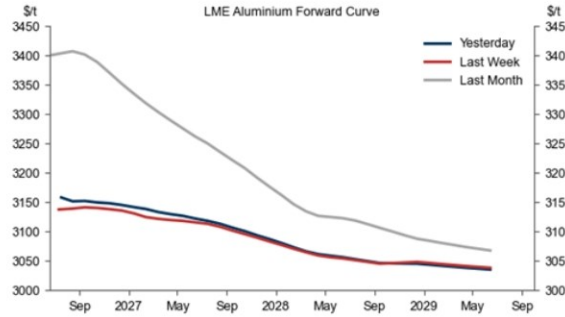
Aluminium: Physical Market Indicators

Exhibit 21: Global Visible Aluminium Inventories Have Declined Since May But Stay Above 2025 Levels



Source: WIND, SMM, Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 22: The LME Aluminium Forward Curve Has Shifted Lower and Become Less Backwardated Over the Past Month



First point is LME cash.

Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

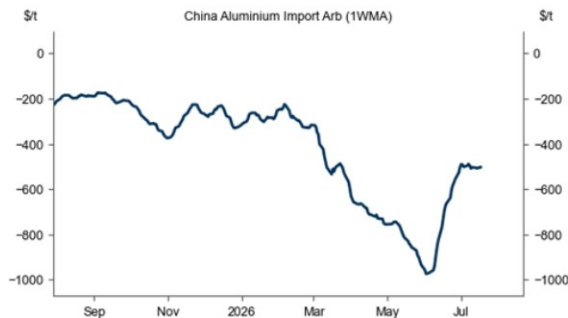
Exhibit 23: Aluminium Premiums Have Pulled Back from Recent Highs



Dashed line = futures curve. Premiums = the price paid on top of the LME price of physical delivery.

Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

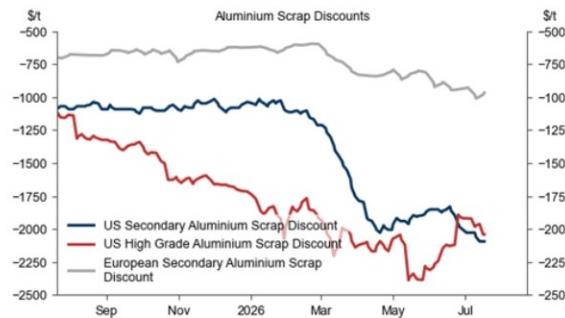
Exhibit 24: The China Aluminium Import Arb Remains Closed



Above zero = incentive for China to import primary aluminium. Aluminium arb is calculated by the SHFE price over LME (accounting for 13% VAT and other import costs).

Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 25: US Aluminium Scrap Discounts Have Widened Sharply in 2026

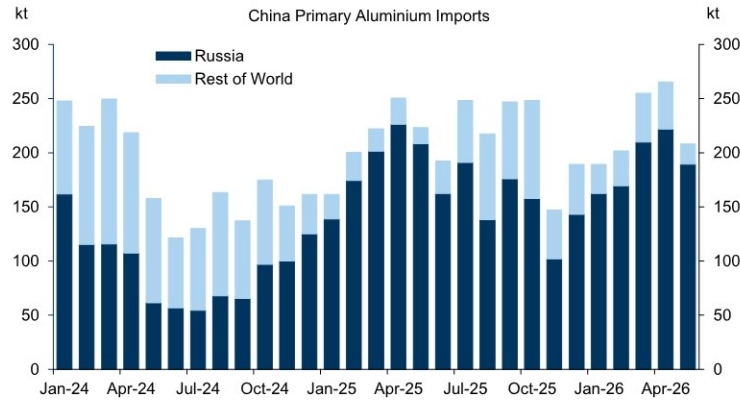


High grade = discount for high grade scrap relative to the alternative material (unalloyed primary metal). Low grade = discount for low grade scrap relative to the product produced (A380/DN226/ADC12). Europe secondary = discount to DN226.

Source: S&P Global Market Intelligence, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

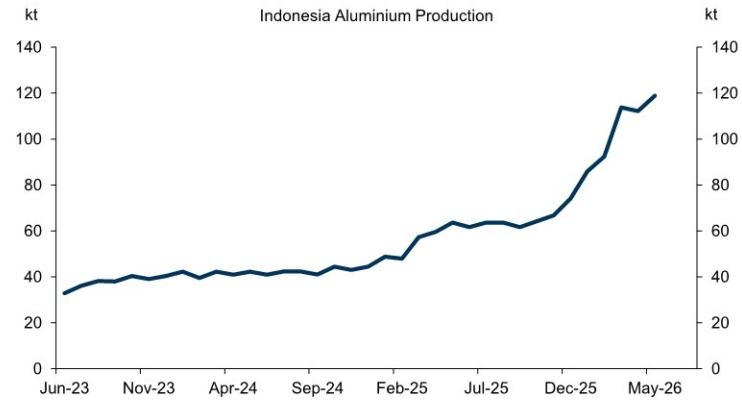
Aluminium: Supply & Demand Tracker

Exhibit 26: Russian Metal Has Driven the Rise in China's Primary Aluminium Imports



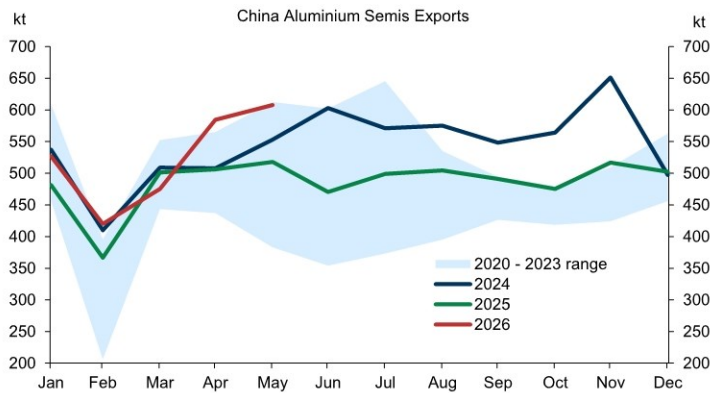
Source: SMM, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 27: Indonesia Aluminium Production is Up 90% YoY YTD



Source: SMM, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 28: China Aluminium Semis Exports Have Risen 17% YoY in May



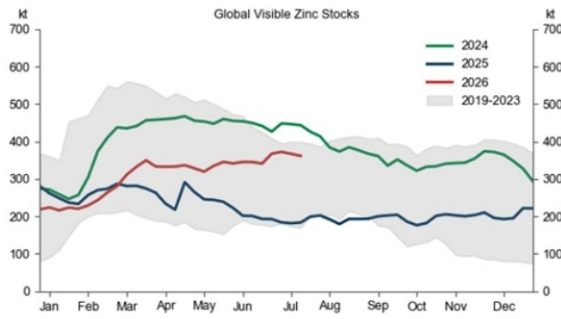
Source: Wind, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 29: Aluminium Consumption is Contracting in Both China and Ex-China

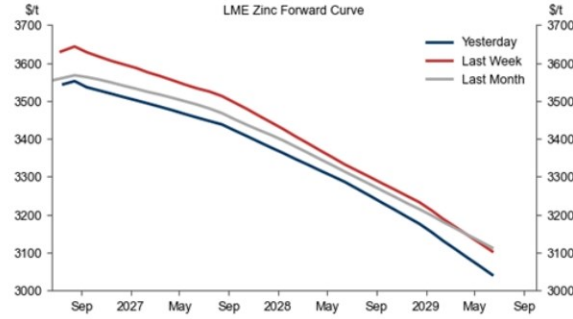


Source: CRU, SMM, GTT, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Zinc: Physical Market Indicators

Exhibit 30: Global Visible Zinc Stocks Have Risen Over the Past Month

Source: WIND, SMM, Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 31: The LME Zinc Forward Curve Remains Backwardated

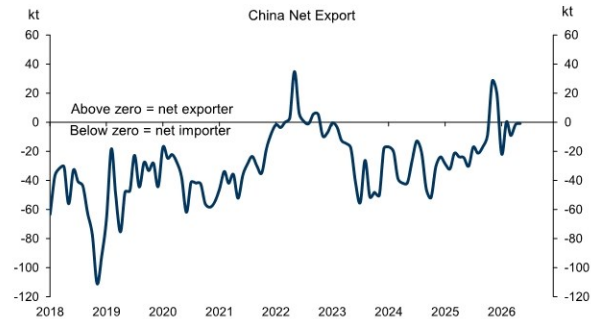
First point is LME cash.

Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

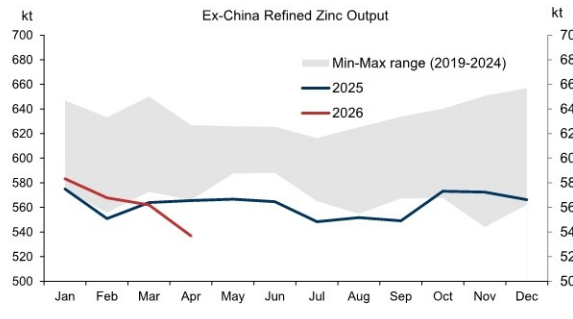
Exhibit 32: The China Zinc Export Arbitrage Is Closed

Above zero = incentive for China to import zinc. Zinc arb is calculated by the SHFE price over LME (accounting for 13% VAT and other import costs).

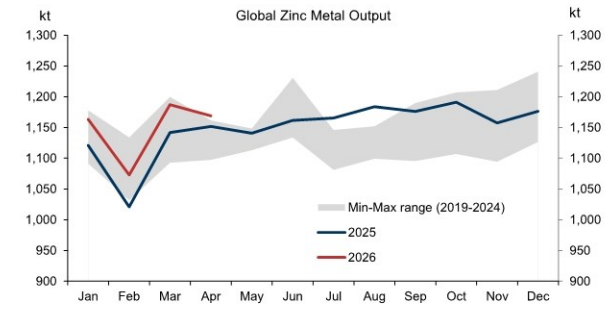
Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 33: China Has Returned to Net Zinc Importer After Briefly Becoming a Net Exporter

Source: China Customs, Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 34: Ex-China Refined Zinc Output Fell Below 2025 Levels in April

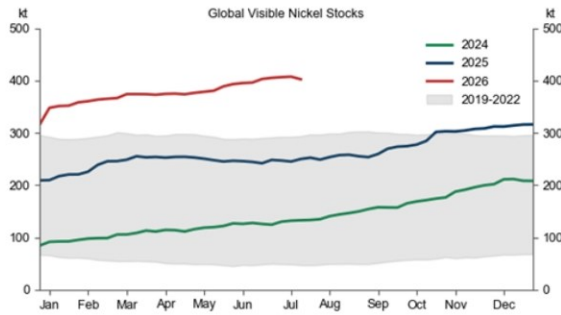
Source: ILZSG, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 35: Higher China Zinc Production Has Offset Weaker Output Elsewhere

Source: ILZSG, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

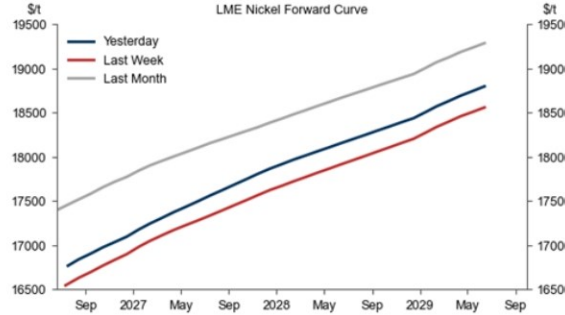
Nickel: Physical Market Indicators

Exhibit 36: Global Visible Nickel Stocks Remain Above the Historical Seasonal Range



Source: WIND, SMM, Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

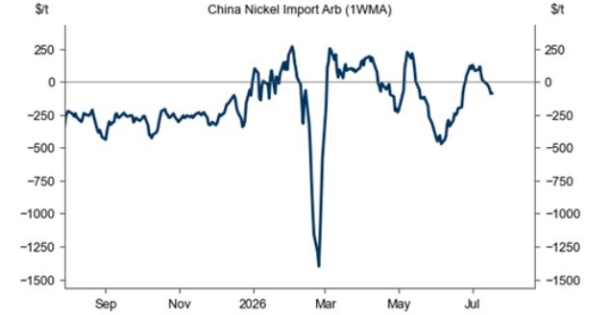
Exhibit 37: The LME Nickel Forward Curve Has Shifted Higher Over the Past Week but Stays in Contango



First point is LME cash.

Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

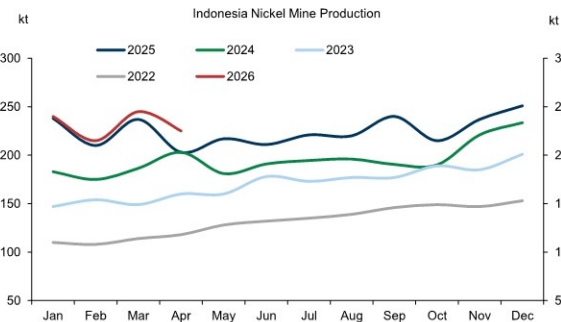
Exhibit 38: The China Nickel Import Arb Has Closed into July



Above zero = incentive for China to import nickel. Nickel arb is calculated by the SHFE price over LME (accounting for 13% VAT and other import costs).

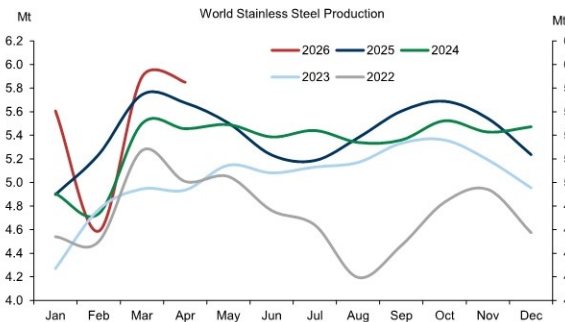
Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 39: Indonesia Nickel Mine Output is Up 2% YoY YTD



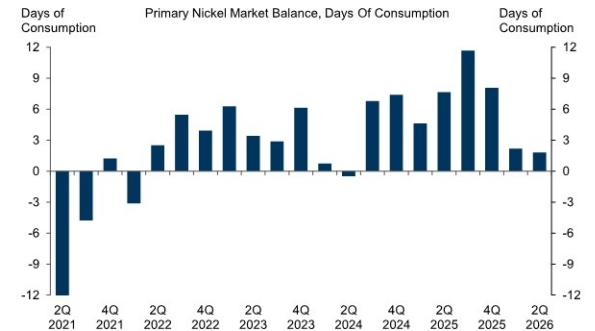
Source: INSG, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 40: World Stainless Steel Production is Tracking 2% Above 2025 YTD



Source: INSG, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

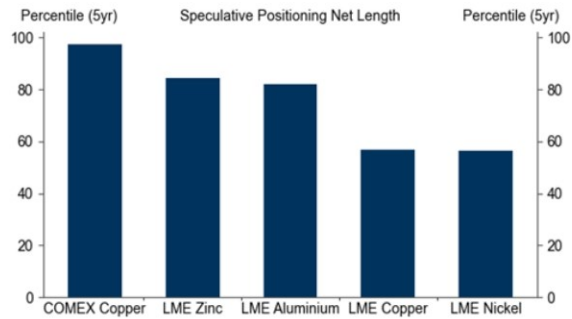
Exhibit 41: Nickel Surplus Has Narrowed in the First Half of the Year



Source: CRU, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

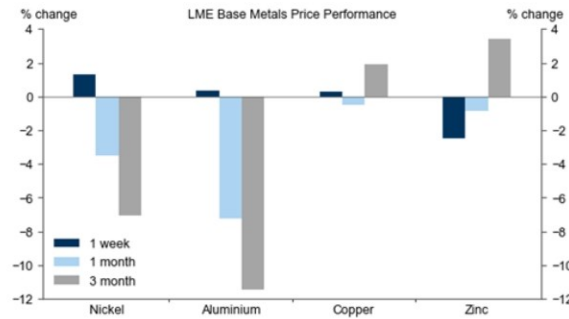
Speculative Positioning

Exhibit 42: Speculative Positioning is Elevated in COMEX Copper, Zinc, Aluminium



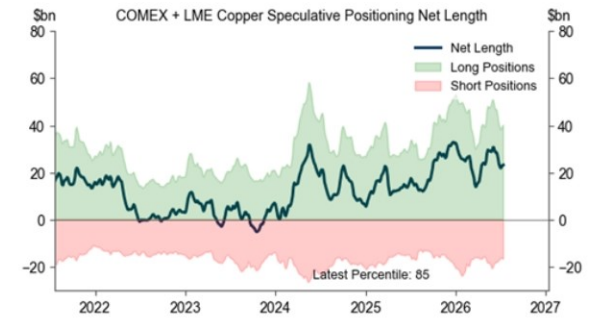
Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 43: Copper and Zinc Have Outperformed Aluminium and Nickel Over the Past Three Months



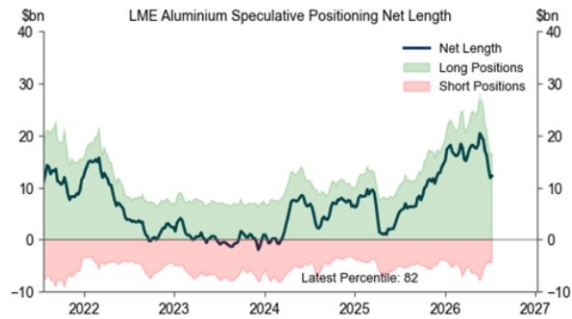
Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 44: Copper Speculative Length Has Eased But is Still Elevated



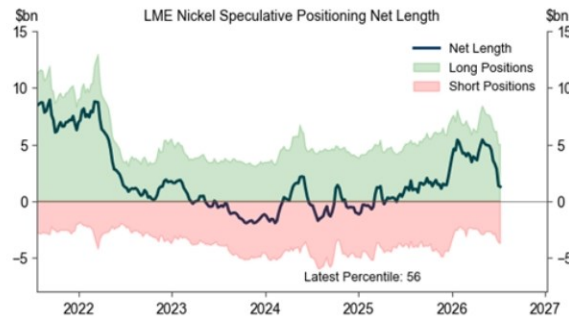
Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 45: LME Aluminium Speculative Net Length Has Fallen Sharply Over the Last Months



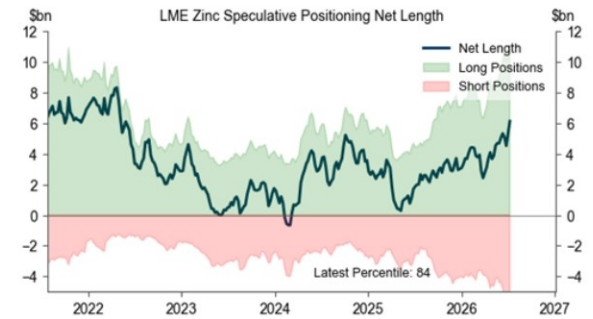
Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 46: LME Nickel Speculative Positioning Has Fallen Back to the 56th Percentile



Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 47: LME Zinc Net Length Has Risen Sharply in Recent Weeks



Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Methodology Notes for GS High Frequency Industrial Metals Indicators

- 1. Global copper inventory:** US unreported stocks increase/decrease when monthly US seaborne cathode imports are over/under 50,000t, adjusted for the change in US exchange inventories. China copper smelter revenue chart:
- 2. Breakeven costs for a low-cost China smelter:** TCRC weighted 50% Benchmark and 50% Spot in 2025. Import arbitrage is the difference in the price paid for all contained metal, less selling price, less VAT. We assume payable/recovery: copper 96%/98.5%, gold and silver 90%/98%.
- 3. China Growth Factor (ex-copper):** The first principal component of PC1 of A- and H- shares, and PC1 of short- and long-term Chinese rates. The methodology is laid out in our cross asset strategists' note: <https://publishing.gs.com/content/research/en/reports/2020/05/13/6a00d7af-7f5a-4a91-993f-41aa73963068.html>.
- 4. Copper to aluminium switching:** Switching index is derived from the value of low-voltage cable exports, relative to copper and aluminium prices. A switch to aluminium, is where we see a higher implied share of aluminium low-voltage cable in the export data. We show the absolute difference between copper and aluminium rather than the typical ratio of copper to aluminium, as our analysis suggests there is more sensitivity from buyers to the price difference rather than the price ratio.

Disclosure Appendix

Reg AC

We, Lavinia Forcellese, Daan Struyven and Samantha Dart, hereby certify that all of the views expressed in this report accurately reflect our personal views, which have not been influenced by considerations of the firm's business or client relationships.

Unless otherwise stated, the individuals listed on the cover page of this report are analysts in Goldman Sachs' Global Investment Research division.

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